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Class/Grade/Year: O Level

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10 **Research Topic:** Social Media, and its Influence on Body Image, Self Esteem and Confidence in Obese Adolescents

Social Media, and its Influence on Body Image, Self Esteem and Confidence in Obese Adolescents

Introduction:

Obesity is a persistent illness that is caused due to the excess amount of body fat, assessed by using Body Mass Index (BMI) which is calculated by the division of weight (kg) and height^2(m^2) [1]. Obesity is seperated into three distinct classes based on the BMI value, Class I obesity consists of a BMI value between 30-35, Class II obesity consists of a BMI value between 35-40, and lastly, Class III obesity which consists of a BMI value above 40 [2]. The causes of obesity include hyperphagia, resistance to insulin and leptin, genetic variations that enable obesity to occur easier and different metabolic systems, while shortage of physical activity, lack of sleep and inordinate amounts of stress are factors that allow obesity to develop quicker [2] [3]. The consequences presented by obesity are higher likelihood of heart diseases and strokes, increased rates of diabetes, Osteoarthritis, digestive and liver diseases, varying forms of sleep apnea and greater risk of internal organ cancer [4]. Nonetheless, there is an absence of understanding between obesity and how social media affects it. This exploratory research will attempt to form a connection between social media usage, obesity, personal body self esteem and confidence, and will document the mentality of different obese adolescents.

Research Question:

1. To what extent does social media affect the self-esteem of obese adolescents?
2. Does consuming negative content influence the personal body image of teenagers with obesity?
3. In what ways can obese adolescents lose confidence by being exposed to posts concerning physical appearance?
4. What types of online post have the most detrimental affect towards obese adolescents' mental health?

Existing Literature:

Obesity

Obesity is a complex, costly yet common disease formed by having too much body fat stored [4], historically, obesity was seen as a form of wealth and prosperity in ancient civilizations such as Egypt, Greece, and Rome [5]. Yet now, in the 21st century, it is a global health crisis epidemic seen in all statuses of countries from underdeveloped to fully developed [1]. However, obesity is

most prevalent in developed countries such as the USA where 1 in 5 children and 2 in 5 adults have obesity [6]. This presents obesity as a disease that cannot be prevented as it is directly related to social and economic issue such as the safety of the environment and the avaliability of organic foods [1] [4].

Social Media and Digital Posts

Social media refers to the collection of online platforms that allow users to connect to one another by posting content and sharing videos [7]. In the 21st century, social media has evolved and is now required in everyday life, from work to school [7]. A key form of entetainment on social media comes in the form of digital posts including the users' physical appearance which has led to an extreme obsession within young teenagers to enhance their body or appearance in order to fit into the standards on social media as stated by reconstructive surgeon Dr. Patrick Byrne [8]. This has had a massive effect on teenagers with obesity whom feel self concious and showed signs of negative body image to the point of drastic measures such as eating disorder symptoms, body dysmorphia, increased anxiety and low self-esteem [8] [9]. The best ways to halt this obsession with body appearance is to limit the time on social media, invest into body positivity content, and attempt not to compare oneself to others [8].

Self-Esteem, Body Image and Confidence

Self-Esteem and Body Image are connected in many ways, self-esteem is the personal sense of dignity one has for themselves, whereas body image is the perception of ones personal appearance and figure [10] [11]. Obesity shapes the body in a way that may be negative to the person as the excess fat may prove to be unlikeable in a way to most social norms, their body image encourages them to try and lose weight [12] [9]. To find information most obese teenagers scour the internet and social media to find tips on weight loss but ended up finding challenges concerning social comparision and negative body image [9]. Not to mention, the social inequality on the internet that affects the confidence of obese adolescents is very dangrous and can lead to desperate attempts such as starving or bed rotting where harmful acts and inactivity is encouraged [13].

Methodology:

This research will use qualitative data and the qualitative part of the research will be backed up by secondary information sources to develop a deep understanding of the mindsets of obese adolescents concerning social media. In-depth interviews (IDIs) will be the main way of qualitative research to ensure that interviewees can reject any questions they are reluctant to answer, and to prevent them from being pressured to reply. The sample size will be selected using the non-probability sampling of judgmental sampling where 10-20 adolescents with

obesity will be selected for the IDIs. This will be done after gaining consent from the teenagers and their guardians while ensuring total anonymity and complete confidentiality.

Conclusion:

Although most obese teenagers may be reluctant to answer due to personal prefernces in disclosing information about their health and weight. The study will display a negative correlation between social media usage to having less self-esteem and lower confidence in their body image in the adolescents with obesity. This connection is due to the negative and toxic content on social media that encourages or cyberbullies teenagers into doing unpresidented actions such a starvation or harmful trends [13].

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